

IELTS WORKSHOP

THE FORUM CENTER - NGUYỄN HOÀNG HUY

TÀI LIỆU CHUYÊN ĐỀ READING

Level 2 — W7 (Feb 9-15)

Can Scientists tell us:

What happiness is?

A

Economists accept that if people describe themselves as happy, then they are happy. However, psychologists differentiate between levels of happiness. The most immediate type involves a feeling; pleasure or joy. But sometimes happiness is a judgment that life is satisfying, and does not imply an emotional state. Esteemed psychologist Martin Seligman has spearheaded an effort to study the science of happiness. The bad news is that we're not wired to be happy. The good news is that we can do something about it. Since its origins in a Leipzig laboratory 130 years ago, psychology has had little to say about goodness and contentment. Mostly psychologists have concerned themselves with weakness and misery. There are libraries full of theories about why we get sad, worried, and angry. It hasn't been respectable science to study what happens when lives go well. Positive experiences, such as joy, kindness, altruism and heroism, have mainly been ignored. For every 100 psychology papers dealing with anxiety or depression, only one concerns a positive trait.

B

A few pioneers in experimental psychology bucked the trend. Professor Alice Isen of Cornell University and colleagues have demonstrated how positive emotions make people think faster and more creatively. Showing how easy it is to give people an intellectual boost, Isen divided doctors making a tricky diagnosis into three groups: one received candy, one read humanistic statements about medicine, one was a control group. The doctors who had candy displayed the most creative thinking and worked more efficiently. Inspired by Isen and others, Seligman got stuck in. He raised millions of dollars of research money and funded 50 research groups involving 150 scientists across the world. Four positive psychology centres opened, decorated in cheerful colours and furnished with sofas and baby-sitters. There were get-togethers on Mexican beaches where psychologists would snorkel and eat fajitas, then form "pods" to discuss subjects such as wonder and awe. A thousand therapists were coached in the new science.

C

But critics are demanding answers to big questions. What is the point of defining levels of haziness and classifying the virtues? Aren't these concepts vague and impossible to pin down? Can you justify spending funds to research positive states when there are problems such as famine, flood and epidemic depression to be solved? Seligman knows his work can be belittled alongside trite notions such as "the power of positive thinking". His plan to stop the new science floating "on the waves of self-improvement fashion" is to make sure it is anchored to positive philosophy above, and to positive biology below.

D

And this takes us back to our evolutionary past. Homo sapiens evolved during the Pleistocene era (1.8 m to 10,000 years ago), a time of hardship and turmoil. It was the Ice Age, and our ancestors

endured long freezes as glaciers formed, then ferocious floods as the ice masses melted. We shared the planet with terrifying creatures such as mammoths, elephant-sized ground sloths and sabre-toothed cats. But by the end of the Pleistocene, all these animals were extinct. Humans, on the other hand, had evolved large brains and used their intelligence to make fire and sophisticated tools, to develop talk and social rituals. Survival in a time of adversity forged our brains into a persistent mould. Professor Seligman says: “Because our brain evolved during a time of ice, flood and famine, we have a catastrophic brain. The way the brain works is looking for what’s wrong. The problem is, that worked in the Pleistocene era. It favoured you, but it doesn’t work in the modern world”.

E

Although most people rate themselves as happy, there is a wealth of evidence to show that negative thinking is deeply ingrained in the human psyche. Experiments show that we remember failures more vividly than success. We dwell on what went badly, not what went well. Of the six universal emotions, four anger, fear, disgust and sadness are negative and only one, joy, is positive. (The sixth, surprise, is neutral). According to the psychologist Daniel Nettle, author of *Happiness*, and one of the Royal Institution lectures, the negative emotion each tells us “something bad has happened” and suggest a different course of action.

F

What is it about the structure of the brain that underlies our bias towards negative thinking? And is there a biology of joy? At Iowa University, neuroscientist studied what happens when people are shown pleasant and unpleasant pictures. When subjects see landscapes or dolphins playing, part of the frontal lobe of the brain becomes active. But when they are shown unpleasant images a bird covered in oil, or a dead soldier with part of his face missing the response comes from more primitive parts of the brain. The ability to feel negative emotions derives from an ancient danger-recognition system formed early in the brain’s evolution. The pre-frontal cortex, which registers happiness, is the part used for higher thinking, an area that evolved later in human history.

G

Our difficulty, according to Daniel Nettle, is that the brain systems for liking and wanting are separate. Wanting involves two ancient regions the amygdala and the nucleus accumbens that communicate using the chemical dopamine to form the brain’s reward system. They are involved in anticipating the pleasure of eating and in addiction to drugs. A rat will press a bar repeatedly ignoring sexually available partners, to receive electrical stimulation of the “wanting” parts of the brain. But having received brain stimulation, the rat eats more but shows no sign of enjoying the food it craved. In humans, a drug like nicotine produces much craving but little pleasure.

H

In essence, what the biology lesson tells us is that negative emotions are fundamental to the human condition and it’s no wonder they are difficult to eradicate. At the same time, by a trick of nature, our brains are designed to crave but never really achieve lasting happiness.

Questions 14-20

The reading Passage has seven paragraphs A-H.

Which paragraph contains the following information?

Write the correct letter A-H, in boxes 14-20 on your answer sheet.

- 14 An experiment involving dividing several groups one of which received positive icon
- 15 Review of a poorly researched psychology area
- 16 Contrast being made about the brains' action as response to positive or negative stimulus
- 17 The skeptical attitude toward the research seemed to be a waste of fund
- 18 a substance that produces much wanting instead of much liking
- 19 a conclusion that lasting happiness is hardly obtained because of the nature of brains
- 20 One description that listed the human emotional categories.

Questions 21-25

Complete the following summary of the paragraphs of Reading Passage

Using NO MORE THAN FOUR WORDS from the Reading Passage for each answer.

Write your answers in boxes 21-25 on your answer sheet.

A few pioneers in experimental psychology study what happens when lives go well. Professor Alice divided doctors, making a tricky experiment, into three groups: besides the one control group, the other two either are asked to read humanistic statements about drugs or received 21..... The latter displayed the most creative thinking and worked more efficiently. Since critics are questioning the significance of the 22..... for both levels of happiness and classification for the virtues. Professor Seligman countered in an evolutionary theory: survival in a time of adversity forged our brains into the way of thinking for what's wrong because we have a 23.....

There is bountiful of evidence to show that negative thinking is deeply built in the human psyche. Later, at Iowa University, neuroscientists studied the active parts in brains to contrast when people are shown pleasant and unpleasant pictures. When positive images like 24..... are shown, part of the frontal lobe of the brain becomes active. But when they are shown unpleasant image, the response comes from 25..... of the brain.

Question 26

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

Write your answers in boxes 26 on your answer sheet.

According to Daniel Nettle in the last two paragraphs, what is true as the scientists can tell us about happiness

- A Brain systems always mix liking and wanting together.
- B Negative emotions can be easily rid of if we think positively.
- C Happiness is like nicotine we are craving for but get little pleasure.

D The inner mechanism of human brains does not assist us to achieve durable happiness

Hướng dẫn giải

Phần I: Câu hỏi 14-20 (Matching Information)

Mục tiêu: Tìm đoạn văn (A-H) chứa các thông tin cụ thể được liệt kê trong câu hỏi.

1. Chiến lược tiếp cận

- Bước 1: Phân tích câu hỏi để xác định từ khóa (keywords) chỉ sự vật, sự việc hoặc hành động đặc trưng.
- Bước 2: Sử dụng kỹ năng đọc lướt (skimming/scanning) để định vị đoạn văn chứa từ khóa hoặc từ đồng nghĩa.
- Bước 3: Đối chiếu thông tin trong đoạn văn với câu hỏi để xác nhận đáp án.

2. Phân tích chi tiết từng câu hỏi

- Câu 14: "An experiment involving dividing several groups one of which received positive icon"
 - Phân tích Từ khóa: "experiment"(thí nghiệm), "dividing"(chia), "groups"(nhóm), "received positive icon"(nhận biểu tượng tích cực).
 - **Định vị và Đối chiếu**
 - * Tại Đoạn B, tác giả mô tả: "...Isen divided doctors... into three groups: one received candy..."
 - * "Candy"(kẹo) được xem là một vật phẩm mang tính tích cực ("positive icon" trong ngữ cảnh phần thưởng nhỏ). Hành động "divided... into three groups" khớp hoàn toàn với từ khóa.
 - Đáp án: B
- Câu 15: "Review of a poorly researched psychology area"
 - Phân tích Từ khóa: "Review"(đánh giá/nhìn nhận lại), "poorly researched"(ít được nghiên cứu), "psychology area"(lĩnh vực tâm lý).
 - **Định vị và Đối chiếu**
 - * Tại Đoạn A, văn bản nêu: "psychology has had little to say about goodness... Positive experiences... have mainly been ignored."
 - * Cụm từ "little to say"(ít nhắc đến) và "ignored"(bị phớt lờ) đồng nghĩa với "poorly researched". Lĩnh vực bị bỏ qua ở đây là "goodness/positive experiences".
 - Đáp án: A
- Câu 16: "Contrast being made about the brains' action as response to positive or negative stimulus"
 - Phân tích Từ khóa: "Contrast"(sự tương phản), "brains' action"(hoạt động của não), "response"(phản ứng), "positive or negative stimulus"(kích thích tích cực hoặc tiêu cực).

◦ **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn F, tác giả so sánh: "When subjects see landscapes (positive)... frontal lobe... becomes active. But when they are shown unpleasant images (negative)... response comes from more primitive parts..."
- * Từ "But" thể hiện sự tương phản (Contrast). Sự khác biệt giữa hoạt động của "frontal lobe" và "primitive parts" chính là "brains' action".

◦ Đáp án: F

• Câu 17: "The skeptical attitude toward the research seemed to be a waste of fund"

- Phân tích Từ khóa: "skeptical attitude" (thái độ hoài nghi), "research", "waste of fund" (lãng phí tiền bạc).

◦ **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn C, có câu hỏi đặt ra bởi các nhà phê bình: "Can you justify spending funds to research positive states when there are problems such as famine...?"
- * Việc đòi hỏi sự biện minh cho việc chi tiêu ("justify spending funds") thể hiện sự lo ngại về việc lãng phí ngân sách ("waste of fund") và thái độ hoài nghi ("critics").

◦ Đáp án: C

• Câu 18: "a substance that produces much wanting instead of much liking"

- Phân tích Từ khóa: "substance" (chất), "produces much wanting" (tạo ra sự thèm muốn lớn), "instead of" (thay vì), "liking" (sự yêu thích).

◦ **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn G, tác giả viết: "...a drug like nicotine produces much craving but little pleasure."
- * "Nicotine" là "substance". "Craving" đồng nghĩa với "wanting". "Little pleasure" tương ứng với ý "instead of much liking".

◦ Đáp án: G

• Câu 19: "a conclusion that lasting happiness is hardly obtained because of the nature of brains"

- Phân tích Từ khóa: "conclusion" (kết luận), "lasting happiness" (hạnh phúc bền lâu), "hardly obtained" (khó đạt được), "nature of brains" (bản chất của não bộ).

◦ **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn H (đoạn kết), tác giả viết: "...our brains are designed to crave but never really achieve lasting happiness."
- * "Designed to" ám chỉ "nature of brains". "Never really achieve" đồng nghĩa với "hardly obtained".

◦ Đáp án: H

• Câu 20: "One description that listed the human emotional categories."

- Phân tích Từ khóa: "description" (mô tả), "listed" (liệt kê), "human emotional categories" (các loại cảm xúc con người).

◦ **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn E, văn bản liệt kê: "Of the six universal emotions, four anger, fear, disgust and sadness... joy... surprise".
- * Việc kể tên cụ thể 6 loại cảm xúc chính là hành động "listed emotional categories".
- o Đáp án: E

Phần II: Câu hỏi 21-25 (Summary Completion)

Mục tiêu: Điền từ vào chỗ trống trong đoạn tóm tắt dựa trên nội dung bài đọc (Không quá 4 từ).

1. Chiến lược tiếp cận

- Bước 1: Xác định từ loại cần điền (danh từ, động từ...) dựa trên ngữ pháp.
- Bước 2: Sử dụng các từ khóa xung quanh chỗ trống để định vị đoạn văn chứa thông tin.
- Bước 3: Chọn từ chính xác trong bài để điền vào.

2. Phân tích chi tiết từng câu hỏi

- Câu 21: "...received [21]..."
 - o Phân tích Từ khóa: "Alice", "divided doctors", "three groups", "control group", "read humanistic statements", "received".
 - o Định vị: Đoạn B chứa thông tin về thí nghiệm của Alice Isen: "...one received candy, one read humanistic statements..."
 - o Đối chiếu: Nhóm còn lại nhận được kẹo.
 - o Đáp án: Candy
- Câu 22: "Since critics are questioning the significance of the [22] for both levels of happiness and classification for the virtues."
 - o Phân tích Từ khóa: "critics", "questioning", "significance", "levels of happiness", "classification for the virtues".
 - o Định vị: Đoạn C: "What is the point of defining levels of haziness and classifying the virtues?"
 - o Đối chiếu: Từ "point" trong bài tương đương với "significance" trong câu hỏi. Hành động được nhắc đến là "defining" (định nghĩa). Lưu ý: Đáp án mẫu là danh từ "definition", đây là dạng từ biến thể của động từ "defining" xuất hiện trong bài để phù hợp ngữ pháp câu tóm tắt.
 - o Đáp án: definition (hoặc defining)
- Câu 23: "...because we have a [23]..."
 - o Phân tích Từ khóa: "Seligman", "evolutional theory", "survival", "adversity", "forged our brains", "what's wrong".
 - o Định vị: Đoạn D: "Professor Seligman says... Because our brain evolved during a time of ice... we have a catastrophic brain."

- Đối chiếu: Cụm từ đi sau "we have" trong bài khớp hoàn toàn với chỗ trống.
- Đáp án: a catastrophic brain
- Câu 24: "When positive images like [24] are shown..."
 - Phân tích Từ khóa: "Iowa University", "neuroscientists", "pleasant and unpleasant pictures", "positive images".
 - Định vị: Đoạn F: "...studied what happens when people are shown pleasant and unpleasant pictures. When subjects see landscapes or dolphins playing..."
 - Đối chiếu: "Landscapes or dolphins playing" là ví dụ cụ thể cho "pleasant pictures" (hình ảnh tích cực).
 - Đáp án: landscapes or dolphins playing
- Câu 25: "...response comes from [25] of the brain."
 - Phân tích Từ khóa: "unpleasant image", "response comes from".
 - Định vị: Đoạn F: "But when they are shown unpleasant images... the response comes from more primitive parts of the brain."
 - Đối chiếu: Thông tin khớp hoàn toàn về nguồn gốc phản ứng của não.
 - Đáp án: (more) primitive parts

Phần III: Câu hỏi 26 (Multiple Choice)

Mục tiêu: Chọn phát biểu đúng dựa trên ý kiến của Daniel Nettle trong hai đoạn cuối.

1. Chiến lược tiếp cận

- Bước 1: Giới hạn phạm vi tìm kiếm ở hai đoạn cuối (G và H) và tên riêng "Daniel Nettle".
- Bước 2: Đọc các lựa chọn A, B, C, D và đối chiếu với bài đọc để loại trừ hoặc chọn.

2. Phân tích chi tiết

- Câu 26: "According to Daniel Nettle in the last two paragraphs, what is true..."
 - **Phân tích lựa chọn**
 - * (A) Brain systems always mix liking and wanting together. -> Sai. Đoạn G nói: "brain systems for liking and wanting are separate" (tách biệt).
 - * (B) Negative emotions can be easily rid of if we think positively. -> Sai. Đoạn H nói: "negative emotions... are difficult to eradicate" (khó loại bỏ).
 - * (C) Happiness is like nicotine we are craving for but get little pleasure. -> Sai. Bài đọc so sánh cơ chế "wanting" (thèm muốn) với nicotine, chứ không định nghĩa "hạnh phúc là nicotine".
 - * (D) The inner mechanism of human brains does not assist us to achieve durable happiness. -> Đúng.
 - **Định vị và Đối chiếu**

- * Tại Đoạn H, tác giả kết luận: "...our brains are designed to crave but never really achieve lasting happiness."
 - * "Never really achieve lasting happiness" đồng nghĩa với việc cơ chế não bộ "does not assist us to achieve durable happiness" (không hỗ trợ đạt được hạnh phúc bền vững).
- Đáp án: D

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